

Obsidian on the Go

A Beginner's Guide to Notes on Your Phone
and Publishing to the Web

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obsidian-troff (0.11.0)

1 Preface

This is a short, friendly guide to **Obsidian** — a note-taking app you can run on your phone, your tablet, and your computer. It assumes **no prior knowledge**. If you have never heard of Obsidian, never written a note in “Markdown,” and are not sure what a “vault” is, you are in exactly the right place.

The book is written with the **phone** in mind, because that is where a lot of real note-taking happens — on the train, in a queue, in bed at 1 a.m. when an idea won’t let you sleep. Everything here works on a desktop too, but the examples lean toward iOS and Android.

The final chapter is a hands-on walkthrough of **Omnighost**, a plugin that turns notes you write in Obsidian into posts on a real website. The screenshots in that chapter are from a live phone, publishing to a real blog.

A note on the pictures: the diagrams are drawn fresh for this book, and the phone screenshots are from the author’s own device. Where this book points you to features in detail, it links to the **official Obsidian documentation** at help.obsidian.md rather than copying it — that is always the most current source.

Let’s begin.

2 What Is Obsidian?

Imagine a drawer full of plain text files — one per idea, project, person, or day. Now imagine that drawer is searchable in an instant, that any note can *link* to any other note, and that the whole thing lives on your own device instead of someone else’s server. That, in one sentence, is Obsidian.

More precisely, Obsidian is an app for writing and connecting notes that are stored as **ordinary files on your device**. Three ideas make it tick.

1. Your notes are plain files. Each note is a normal text file with a `.md` extension (more on `.md` in a moment). You can open them in any other program, back them up like any other file, and read them in fifty years without needing Obsidian at all. Nothing is locked inside a proprietary database.

2. Your notes live in a “vault.” A *vault* is just a folder on your device that Obsidian watches. Everything in that folder — notes, images, sub-folders — is your vault. You can have one vault for everything, or several (work, personal, a journal). A vault is portable: copy the folder, and you’ve copied your whole knowledge base.

A vault is a folder containing Markdown notes, project folders, and images.

3. Notes connect to each other. The real magic is *linking*. Any note can point to any other note, and Obsidian remembers the connection in both directions. Over time your notes stop being a pile and start being a *web* — a personal Wikipedia where you are the only editor and the only reader.

2.1 Why people like it

- **Local and private.** By default your notes never leave your device unless you choose to sync or publish them.
- **It outlives the app.** Plain Markdown files are about as future-proof as a digital format gets.
- **It grows with you.** Start with a grocery list; end with a research system. The app doesn’t force a structure on you.

- **It’s extensible.** A large community builds *plugins* that add features — including the one in the last chapter of this book.

2.2 What Markdown is (the 90-second version)

Markdown is a way of writing formatted text using plain characters. Instead of clicking a “bold” button, you wrap a word in asterisks. Instead of a heading style, you start a line with #. It looks like this:

```
# A heading
```

```
This is a paragraph with a bold word and an italic one.
```

```
- a bullet
- another bullet
```

```
> a quoted line
```

You don’t have to memorize it — Obsidian shows you the formatted result as you type, and there is a one-page cheat sheet at the back of this book. The point is that the formatting is *part of the text*, so your notes stay readable anywhere.

3 Getting Started on Your Phone

Obsidian is free to download. The fastest path on a phone:

1. Open the **App Store** (iPhone/iPad) or **Google Play** (Android) and search for **Obsidian**. Install it.
2. Open the app. The first time, it offers to **create a vault** or open an existing one. Choose **Create new vault**, give it a name (e.g. *Notes*), and pick where it lives.
3. On iPhone you’ll typically choose between storing the vault **on your device** or **in iCloud Drive** (handy if you also use a Mac). On Android you pick a folder. Either is fine to start; you can move it later.
4. Tap the + (new note), type something, and you’ve made your first note.

That’s genuinely it — you now have a working second brain in your pocket.

3.1 A quick tour of the screen

On a phone the interface is deliberately spare. A few things to find:

- The **note area** in the middle, where you read and write.
- A **left sidebar** (swipe from the left edge, or tap the menu icon) with your **file list** and **search**.
- A **right sidebar** (swipe from the right) with extras like **backlinks** and the **outline**.
- A **command palette** — a searchable list of *everything* the app can do. You’ll use this constantly; we’ll meet it properly in Chapter 6.
- A **ribbon** of icons for common actions and for plugins.

If you ever feel lost, remember two gestures: **swipe from the left** for your files, and open the **command palette** to search for any action by name.

3.2 On editing modes

Obsidian can show a note two ways. **Live Preview** formats text as you write (bold looks bold). **Source mode** shows the raw Markdown characters. Beginners usually live in Live Preview; switch to Source when you want to see exactly what's in the file. You can toggle between them from the command palette or the note's "more options" menu.

4 Writing in Markdown

You already saw the basics. Here is the working set you'll use 95% of the time.

Headings structure a note. One # is the biggest; more # make smaller sub-headings.

```
# Title
## Section
### Sub-section
```

Emphasis:

```
*italic*   or  _italic_
**bold**   or  __bold__
~~strikethrough~~
```

Lists — bullets with -, numbers with 1.:

- milk
 - eggs
-
1. wake up
 2. coffee

Checkboxes turn a list into a to-do list. Tap a box in Live Preview to check it off:

- [] write a note
- [x] install Obsidian

Quotes and code:

> A quoted thought.

Inline ``code`` for a command. For several lines of code or commands, fence them with thr

Images can be dropped or pasted into a note; Obsidian stores the file in your vault and writes a link to it for you.

The golden rule: when in doubt, just *type*. Markdown is forgiving, and anything it doesn't recognize is simply shown as plain text.

5 Linking Your Thoughts

This is the chapter that turns a notes app into *Obsidian*.

To link from one note to another, type two square brackets and start typing a name:

See also [[Books to read]] and [[Garden]].

As you type inside the brackets, Obsidian suggests matching notes. Pick one and you've made a link. Tap the link later to jump there. If the target note doesn't exist yet, the link is created "empty" — tap it and Obsidian makes the note for you. This is a lovely way to write: mention an idea now, flesh it out later.

5.1 Backlinks: connections in reverse

Here's the part that feels like magic. If note A links to note B, then note B automatically knows that A points at it. Open B, look at its **Backlinks** panel, and you'll see every note that mentions it — without you ever editing B.

Backlinks show which notes point at the current note.

Backlinks mean you never lose a thought. Write about your garden in today's journal, and the *Garden* note quietly collects every mention over the months.

5.2 The graph

Obsidian can draw your whole vault as a **graph**: each note is a dot, each link a line. Early on it's a few scattered dots. After a few hundred notes it becomes a constellation, and clusters appear where your real interests live. The graph is more fun than useful at first — but it's a great way to *see* your thinking take shape.

5.3 Tags

Sometimes you don't want a whole note for a topic — you just want a label. Type a # followed by a word, with no space:

Had a great idea on the bus today. #ideas #commute

Tags are searchable and clickable. They're a lighter-weight cousin of links: links connect specific notes; tags gather many notes under a theme.

6 Organizing a Vault

There is no single “right” way to organize Obsidian, which is liberating and, at first, slightly terrifying. Three tools help, and you can mix them freely.

Folders work exactly as you'd expect — drag notes into them, nest them. Good for coarse separation (Work, Personal, Journal). Don't over-think folders; linking and search make deep hierarchies unnecessary.

Tags (from the last chapter) cut *across* folders. A note in *Work/* can carry #idea right alongside a note in *Personal/*.

Properties are the most powerful and the least obvious, so they get their own section.

6.1 Properties (the note's “data”)

Every note can carry a small block of structured information at the very top, called **properties** (the underlying format is called *YAML frontmatter*). It's fenced by three dashes:

```
---
title: Trip to Los Cabos
status: draft
tags: [travel, 2026]
rating: 5
---
```

The body of the note starts here.

Each line is a **key** and a **value**. Obsidian shows these as a tidy **Properties panel** at the top of the note, with the right input for each type — a checkbox for yes/no, a date picker for dates, a list

editor for lists.

A note's Properties panel on a phone.
The keys on the left (here prefixed `ghost_`) each have an editor on the right — text, checkboxes, and lists.
Long key names are truncated; tap one to see it in full.

Why bother? Because properties make notes *queryable and automatable*. Plugins read them, dashboards filter on them, and — as you'll see in the final chapter — a publishing plugin uses them to decide a post's title, visibility, and schedule. For now, just know that the block at the top of a note is where the *structured* information lives, separate from the prose below it.

7 Finding Things

A vault is only as good as your ability to get back to a note. Obsidian gives you three fast paths, and all three are reachable from the phone.

Search (the magnifying glass in the left sidebar) looks through the full text of every note. It supports quoted phrases and simple operators, but plain words get you a long way.

Quick Switcher jumps to a note by name. Open the command palette and run “Quick switcher,” type a few letters of a note's title, and hit it. This is the single fastest way to navigate once you know roughly what you're looking for.

Command Palette is the master key. It's a searchable list of *every* command in the app and its plugins — “Toggle Live Preview,” “Open graph view,” “Create new note,” and hundreds more. You don't need to memorize menus; you just remember a word or two and search. On a phone it's usually a toolbar icon or a swipe-down; bind it to something comfortable and use it for everything.

Tip: most actions you'll read about in this book — including the Omnighost commands later — are run from the command palette by typing part of their name.

8 Making Obsidian Yours: Plugins

Out of the box, Obsidian is intentionally modest. Its power comes from **plugins**, and there are two kinds.

[IMAGE:]

Core plugins are made by the Obsidian team and ship with the app. They're just toggled on or off in **Settings** â **Core plugins**. Many features you've already met — Backlinks, Graph view, Daily notes, Templates, Outline — are core plugins. If something seems missing, check here first; it may simply be switched off.

Community plugins are built by other people and published to an in-app directory. They unlock workflows the core app never tries to cover: calendars, task boards, spaced-repetition flashcards, and the Ghost publishing plugin in the next chapter.

8.1 Turning on community plugins safely

The first time you want a community plugin, Obsidian asks you to acknowledge that these are third-party add-ons (sensible — they run real code). Once you've turned the feature on, you can **Browse** the directory, install a plugin, and **enable** it. Each plugin lives in your vault under a hidden `.obsidian/plugins/` folder, so it travels with the vault.

A few habits keep this pleasant:

- **Install what you'll use**, not everything that looks interesting.
- **Read the plugin's page** for what permissions or setup it needs.
- **Update occasionally** — plugins improve, and updates are one tap.

There's also a popular community plugin called **BRAT** that installs and auto-updates plugins straight from a GitHub repository. It's the easiest way to run a plugin that isn't (yet) in the official directory — which is exactly how you'll install Omnighost on a phone in the final chapter.

9 Syncing Across Devices

Most people want the same notes on their phone and their computer. Because a vault is just a folder, you have several ways to keep it in step.

[IMAGE:]

Obsidian Sync is the official, paid service. It's the most reliable option, encrypts your notes end-to-end, handles conflicts gracefully, and works across every platform with no fiddling. If syncing matters to you, it's the least painful choice.

iCloud Drive (Apple devices) is free and built in: put the vault in iCloud and your iPhone, iPad, and Mac share it. It works well for one person on Apple gear, though it can be slower to settle than Sync and is less forgiving if two devices edit the same note at the same moment.

Other options exist — third-party cloud drives, or **Git** for the technically inclined (which also gives you a full history). These are more setup but more control.

Two pieces of advice regardless of method:

- **Pick one sync method** and stick with it. Layering two (say iCloud *and* Sync) is how conflicts are born.
- **Keep a backup.** Sync is not a backup — it faithfully copies your mistakes too. Because your vault is plain files, any normal backup works.

10 Publishing to the Web with Omnighost

So far your notes have stayed private. This chapter is about the other direction: taking a note you wrote in Obsidian and **publishing it as a post on a real website** — and, crucially, **updating** that post later from the same note, without creating duplicates. The tool is a community plugin called **Omnighost**.

10.1 What is Ghost, and what does the plugin do?

Ghost is a popular publishing platform — think of it as software that runs a blog or newsletter, like a leaner, modern WordPress. A Ghost site has *posts*, each with a title, body, tags, an excerpt, a visibility setting (public or members-only), and a publish date.

Omnighost connects your Obsidian vault to one or more Ghost sites. You write in Obsidian as usual; the plugin pushes the note to Ghost as a post. Publish the same note again and it *updates the existing post in place* rather than spawning a copy. If you run several blogs, one note can publish to one site, several sites, or stay out of sync entirely.

Omnighost reads an Obsidian note and local images, creates or updates the Ghost post, and writes post identifiers back to the note.

The flow is worth understanding because it explains the whole plugin:

1. The note's **properties** (a set of keys, by convention prefixed `ghost_` or `g_`) tell Omnighost which blog(s) to target, whether the post is a draft or published, who can read it, when it should go live, and which tags/images to use.
2. On the **first publish**, the plugin creates the post and writes that blog's **id**, Ghost editor URL, and public URL back into the note's properties.
3. On **later syncs**, it reads those stored ids and updates the exact same Ghost posts. In multi-blog notes, each target blog gets its own id and URL keys.
4. Any **local images** in the note are uploaded to Ghost and the links rewritten, so pictures actually appear on the web.

10.2 Installing it on a phone

Omnighost is distributed as a community plugin. The easiest mobile route is the **BRAT** plugin mentioned earlier:

1. Install and enable **BRAT** from the community plugin directory.
2. Run the command "**BRAT: Add a beta plugin for testing**" and give it the plugin's repository (e.g. `alexys/omnighost`).
3. Enable **Omnighost** under **Settings â Community plugins**.

(You can also install it by hand: copy the plugin's `main.js`, `manifest.json`, and `styles.css` into `.obsidian/plugins/omnighost/` in your vault.)

10.3 Connecting to your site

In **Settings â Omnighost**, the first section is **Ghost blogs**. Add one block per Ghost site. Each blog has:

- a display **Name**;
- a **Site address** such as `https://yourblog.com`;
- an **Admin API Key**, which you create in Ghost admin under *Settings â Integrations â Add custom integration* and paste into that blog's key field;
- a vault **Folder** for that blog's posts;
- an **Auto-sync this folder** toggle; and
- an optional per-blog **Sync interval**.

Tap **Save key** for each blog. Omnighost stores the key in Obsidian's secure keychain and immediately tests the connection. A good connection greets you by the Ghost site's name. If two blogs accidentally share the same keychain secret, settings warns you, because the wrong key will fail with a Ghost 401.

10.4 The properties that control a post

Each note you publish carries a few special properties. With the current default prefix they read `ghost_...`; many people shorten the prefix to `g_...` so the names fit better on a phone. The essentials:

- `g_blog` — a list of blog names or domain keys. Omit it to use the default blog.
- `g_published` — a checkbox. **Off** keeps the post a *draft*; **on** publishes it.

- `g_post_access` — the visibility: `public`, `members`, or `paid`.
- `g_published_at` — a date, used only when you want to *schedule* a post for the future.
- `g_slug` — the post’s URL ending. Leave it empty to derive one from the title.
- `g_tags`, `g_excerpt`, `g_feature_image`, `g_cover_from_first_image` — tags, a short summary, a cover image, and the optional “use the first body image as cover” behavior.
- `g_no_sync` — a per-note safety switch. Turn it on to skip that note.
- `g_id_example_com`, `g_url_example_com`, `g_public_url_example_com` — written by the plugin after a successful publish to `example.com`. You don’t edit these; they’re how Omnighost finds that blog’s post again and how you reach it on the web.

Older notes may have clean keys like `g_id` or map keys like `g_ids`. Omnighost migrates those forward as it syncs. The command **Normalize blog references (use domain keys)** rewrites blog references to stable domain-based keys, so renaming a blog does not break note-to-post links.

10.5 The easy way: the properties modal

Editing those keys by hand in the native Properties panel works, but the values are free text — easy to mistype `Public` when Ghost wants `public`. Omnighost adds a dedicated **Edit ghost properties** dialog (open it from the ghost ribbon icon, the editor’s right-click menu, or the command palette) with proper controls:

- **Status** — a dropdown: *Draft*, *Publish now*, or *Schedule* (which reveals a date field).
- **Visibility** — a dropdown: *Public*, *Members only*, or *Paid*.
- Toggles for *Featured* and *Use first image as cover*.
- Plain text for *Tags*, *Slug*, *Excerpt*, *Feature image*.
- If you have more than one blog configured, a **Blogs** checklist for choosing exactly where this note publishes.
- A status line showing whether the post is **Published** (with the live URL and a copy button) once it has actually gone out.
- Two buttons: **Save** (write the properties) and **Save & sync** (write *and* publish in one tap).

Because the choices are dropdowns, you can’t accidentally enter an invalid value. That single dialog is the recommended way to publish.

10.6 A first publish, start to finish

1. Write a note. Give it a real title — either a # Heading at the top or a sensible filename, because the title drives the post’s web address.
2. Open **Edit ghost properties**.
3. Set **Status** to *Publish now*, **Visibility** to *Public*.
4. Tap **Save & sync**.
5. Watch the status line flip to **Published** with a live link, and tap the copy button to grab the URL.

Here’s the result on the open web — a note written on a phone, now a public post:

The same note published as a public post on a Ghost site, viewed in a mobile browser.

The subscribe box at the bottom is Ghost’s standard newsletter call-to-action on public posts —

not a paywall.

To **change** the post later, edit the note and **Save & sync** again. The plugin finds the existing post by its stored id and updates it — same URL, no duplicate. You can also run **Sync current note to ghost** from the command palette, or use the periodic folder sync if it is enabled for that blog.

10.7 Publishing to more than one blog

Omnighost can manage several Ghost sites at once — handy if you run a personal blog and a work newsletter, or mirror the same writing to two places.

One note can route through Omnighost to several Ghost blogs, each with its own folder, key, and post identity.

In **Settings â Omnighost**, the **Ghost blogs** section lets you **Add blog**. Each one gets its own name, site address, Admin API key (a keychain secret), folder in your vault, sync toggle, and optional interval. One blog is marked the default (â), and a **Test** button confirms each connection by name.

To choose where a note goes, run the command “**Set blog(s) for this note.**” A checklist appears; tick one or more blogs and confirm. Your choice is saved in the note’s **g_blog** property and sticks. If you tick several blogs, syncing the note publishes — and later updates — *all* of them at once. The last blog you pick becomes the default for the next new note.

Selective sync has two levels. For one note, set `g_no_sync: true` and Omnighost leaves it alone. For a whole blog folder, turn off **Auto-sync this folder** in that blog’s settings; manual sync still works when you ask for it.

To bring an existing site into Obsidian, run “**Import all posts from a ghost blog,**” choose one or more blogs, and every post arrives as a note in that blog’s folder, already tagged with its `g_blog` and per-blog id/URL keys. To import one post, use **Import post from ghost** with the Ghost editor URL. To connect an existing note to an existing Ghost post, use **Link note to ghost post** and choose whether Ghost overwrites the note or the note syncs up to Ghost.

One thing to know: a note’s identity on each blog is its stored id, with the slug as the fallback before the first id is written. Keep slugs stable once a note is published widely. If you remove a blog from `g_blog` after the note has already published there, the next interactive sync warns about the orphaned Ghost post. You can delete it on Ghost, keep it by re-adding that blog, or decide later.

10.8 Bulk delete and safe cleanup

Publishing tools need a careful delete story. Omnighost never deletes remote posts silently.

Bulk delete is a checklist workflow with final confirmation, optional per-post prompts, and local archive support.

Run “**Bulk delete posts (local notes + ghost)**” to choose one or more blogs. Omnighost lists the linked notes and Ghost posts it can find. Everything starts checked; uncheck anything you want to keep. When you confirm, Omnighost deletes only the selected Ghost posts. It also removes the selected local notes.

If **Archive deleted notes** is on, local notes move into an archive subfolder inside their blog folder instead of going to trash. Omnighost stamps them with archive metadata and `g_no_sync: true`, so archived notes are not accidentally re-published. If the archive option is off, the notes

go to Obsidian trash.

Two extra settings control how cautious the workflow is:

- **Prompt on folder delete** — if you delete a folder of synced notes, Omnighost opens the same checklist for their linked Ghost posts. The notes are already gone locally, but the Ghost posts are still untouched until you confirm.
- **Confirm each remote delete** — during a bulk delete, Omnighost shows each post and blog name with **Delete**, **Skip**, and **Stop**.

10.9 When something goes wrong

Ghost validates posts, and when a field is off it returns a precise message. Reading that message is the fastest way to fix it:

A Ghost validation error surfaced in Obsidian.

The text names the exact problem — here, a slug longer than Ghost’s 191-character limit — which points straight at the fix.

A few common cases and what they mean:

- **“Successfully connected” shows the wrong name, or connection fails** — that blog’s Ghost URL or Admin API Key is wrong. Re-enter them in the blog block; the greeting confirms the right site.
- **A slug-length error** (as pictured) — the note had no heading, so the title fell back to a long first paragraph. Give the note a short # `Heading` or set `g_slug` explicitly.
- **The post looks “paywalled” but you set it public** — check the body: if the *content* is visible and only a *Subscribe* box sits at the bottom, that box is Ghost’s normal newsletter call-to-action on public posts, not a lock. Confirm the visibility in Ghost admin to be sure.
- **It shows “Published” but you got an error** — newer versions tie the green “Published” badge to a real published URL, so a failed sync won’t falsely show green. If yours does, update the plugin.
- **A blog sync says the key is missing** — each blog needs its own stored Admin API key. Paste the key into that blog’s **Admin API key** field and tap **Save key**.

10.10 Why updating is the whole point

Plenty of tools can *post* from a note. The hard part — and the reason this plugin exists — is *re-posting the same note without making a mess*. Omnighost keeps a stable link between one note and each of its Ghost posts: edit the note, sync, and the live posts change in place. Your Obsidian vault stays the single source of truth, and the web stays in step with it.

11 Where to Go Next

You now have the whole loop: capture ideas as notes, connect them with links, organize lightly with folders, tags, and properties, find anything in a tap, extend the app with plugins, sync across your devices, and — when a note is ready for the world — publish it to a Ghost site and keep it updated.

A few directions from here:

- **Lean on the official docs.** The most current, detailed reference is at *help.obsidian.md*, with developer material at *docs.obsidian.md*. When a menu or setting looks different from this

book, trust the docs — apps move fast.

- **Try the community.** Obsidian has an active forum and Discord where people share workflows and plugins.
- **Start a daily note.** The single habit that makes Obsidian “click” for most people is writing one note per day and linking out from it.
- **Back up.** Your notes are plain files; treat them as precious and copy them somewhere safe.

Most of all: don’t over-engineer it. The best note system is the one you actually use. Open the app, tap +, and write the next thing down.

12 Appendix A: Markdown Cheat Sheet

# Heading 1	## Heading 2	### Heading 3
bold	<i>*italic*</i>	~~strikethrough~~
- bullet	1. numbered	- [] / - [x] task
> quote	`inline code`	[[Link to a note]]
#tag	![alt] (image.png)	[text] (https://link)

(For multi-line code, fence it with three backticks on their own lines.)

13 Appendix B: Omnighost Property Reference

With the default prefix the keys begin `ghost_`; many users shorten it to `g_`. The table below uses `g_` for compactness. If your prefix is `ghost_`, read `g_published` as `ghost_published`, and so on.

Property	Type	Meaning
<code>g_blog</code>	list of names or domains	Which blog(s) the note publishes to (default if absent)
<code>g_published</code>	checkbox	Off = draft, on = published
<code>g_post_access</code>	public / members / paid	Who can read it
<code>g_published_at</code>	date	Future date schedules the post
<code>g_featured</code>	checkbox	Mark as a featured post
<code>g_slug</code>	text	URL ending (empty = from title)
<code>g_tags</code>	list	Post tags
<code>g_excerpt</code>	text	Short summary (max 300 chars)
<code>g_feature_image</code>	text	Cover image URL
<code>g_cover_from_first_image</code>	checkbox	Use the first body image as the cover
<code>g_no_sync</code>	checkbox	Skip this note when syncing
<code>g_id_<blog></code>	written by plugin	The Ghost id for one target blog, using a domain-based suffix
<code>g_url_<blog></code>	written by plugin	The Ghost editor link for that blog’s post

<code>g_public_url_<blog></code>	written by plugin	The live, public web address for that blog's post
<code>g_archived</code>	written by plugin	True when a bulk-deleted local note is archived
<code>g_archived_at</code>	written by plugin	When the note was moved into the archive folder
<code>g_archived_from</code>	written by plugin	The note's original vault path before archive

Legacy single-blog notes may contain `g_id`, `g_url`, or `g_public_url`. Omnighost reads them for compatibility and migrates toward per-blog keys on later syncs.

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